

The Gandhi scion has become a one-man organisation, setting the agenda and rewriting it at whim

THE CONGRESS LINE

At first the party quibbled over Advani's figures. Later Manmohan said he'll bring the money back within 100 days if voted to power.

Like Rahul, the prime minister has kept an ambivalent stand towards the Left. Sonia, however, has accused it of running a dictatorship in West Bengal and Kerala.

There is a section which wants to dump both Lalu and Paswan. But with Nitish sticking with the NDA, Rahul's public overtures have embarrassed the party.

Chief Minister YSR Reddy has just conducted a campaign attacking Naidu. His rival's praise won't go down well. However, Sonia hasn't attacked Naidu in her campaigns.

few days ago. He thundered then: "The communists in Bengal have been caught in an ideological bind. That too an outdated one, one that has failed in all other places. Last year, I went to China and the Chinese communists asked me, What kind of communism is practiced in Bengal? Why don't they change?"

Any sane person would ask this question. The mother also didn't spare the commies when she toured the state. "The state Government



IN BETWEEN ADDRESSING MORE THAN 100 MEETINGS, RAHUL UNWINDS BY CATCHING UP ON HIS READING

will have to answer why they have not done anything for the poor," she had said. For a while, even the prime minister was pretty daring in his anti-communism. Then one day, in the company of women journalists, he too changed the tone: "I have great regard and respect for my Left colleagues. I have repeatedly said that I greatly regret their leaving. As for the future, who can judge? We will cross that bridge when we get there." Maybe both Manmohan, the immediate choice of the party, and Rahul, the inevitable choice of the future, think they are getting there, and they need the support of that party with an outdated ideology to cross the bridge. Or, is it that Rahul has become the message—a message that defies the standard party line? Or, is it that he has become the party? It is as if he has all of a sudden realised the privileges of his

surname. He has become the one-man organisation setting the agenda and rewriting it at whim. Being the Inevitable One, he doesn't have to adjust to the party. The party will adjust to him. His stream-of-consciousness politics has only confused his party and confounded his enemies. And it has hardly made him more comprehensible.

He is certainly playing a different kind of politics and the party elders are not getting it. Although most of the Congress leadership is not part of the decision-making process within the party, they are however aware of the endless rounds of discussions that take place between the Congress president and her core group before she finally takes a decision. Rahul's style, in contrast, belongs to the lone ranger trigger-happy style of politics. And one that seems to have mystified the party's foes and friends alike. Allies like the

"I am thankful to him and nothing more. But We are in the NDA, and we are working hard for the victory of the NDA."

NITISH KUMAR, Bihar Chief Minister